5NT Pick a Slam

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5NT Pick a Slam can be used when you want to play in a small slam, but need partner to help choose the best strain. Any 5NT bid asks partner to P.A.S.S. (ha ha) - "Pick A Small Slam."

Partner is expected to use his best judgement based on the bidding up to that point. He can bid any suit naturally, or simply bid 6NT if he is certain about no-trumps.

Examples

The following examples are from Marty Bergen's book "Slam Bidding Made Easier".

Opener	Responder
♠AT9	♠KQ74
♥K4	♥AQJ9
♦KQJ9852	♦T
♣9	♣A642

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
3♦	5NT (1)
6♦ (2)	Pass

1. 5NT Pick a Slam
2. Affirming a self-sufficient trump suit

Opener	Responder
♠A4	♠K953
♥KQ3	♥A85
♦K642	♦A5
♣QJT8	♣AK72

Opener	Responder
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♦ (2)	5NT (3)
6♣ (4)	Pass

1. Stayman
2. No 4-card major
3. 5NT Pick a Slam
4. Suggesting the cheapest 4-card suit

Compare the above auction to normal methods. Bergen suggests that responder might blast 6NT over 2♦, which would fail by a trick.

Opener	Responder
♠AQJ9	♠KT4
♥AKJ	♥Q85
♦7	♦AJ8653
♣KJ742	♣A

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♦
2♠	3♦
3NT	5NT (1)
6♠ (2)	Pass

1. 5NT Pick a Slam
2. Showing a very good 4-card suit

The 6♠ bid that Bergen suggests is cleverly nuanced. First, opener's failure to bid 6♦ indicates a lack of diamond tolerance. Second, opener's previous 3NT bid implied 4-5 shape in the black suits. So the 6♠ bid cannot be some kind of 5-6 monster. It suggests an imbalanced hand that's willing to play in a Moysian fit (given that responder failed to raise spades earlier).

Opener	Responder
♠J96432	♠A
♥75	♥AK84
♦AK	♦QJT96
♣KT9	♣AQ4

Opener	Responder
1♠	2♦
2♠	3♥
3NT	5NT (1)
6♦ (2)	Pass

1. 5NT Pick a Slam
2. Showing diamond tolerance

Opener's 6♦ shows diamond tolerance given his prior inability to raise the suit.

All in all Bergen states that 5NT Pick a Slam is his favorite slam convention "because both players are involved in the decision-making process. The partnership will arrive at the contract only after mutual agreement."

The 5NT Bidder's Rebids

After hearing partner's response, the 5NT bidder can simply pass, bid another suit naturally, or bid 6NT.

Other Considerations

- When using 5NT Pick a Slam, you must be confident that your side can make a small slam. However, you must also be certain that you don't belong in a grand slam. (Otherwise, you should use bidding methods for exploring a grand.)
- The only exception to the 5NT Pick a Slam convention is a 5NT Blackwood rebid which asks for kings.

- 5NT Pick a Slam conflicts with the Grand Slam Force convention, which asks partner to bid a grand slam with 2 of the top 3 honors in the agreed trump suit. The loss of GSF can be negated by employing Roman Key Card Blackwood for inquiring about top honors.

  Larry Cohen (of the Law of Total Tricks) has gone so far as to say that 5NT Pick a Slam has made GSF "obsolete."

See also

- Baby Blackwood
  A conventional 3NT ace-asking bid after a major-suit fit is found.
- Blackwood
  The original 4NT convention invented by Easley Blackwood to ask for aces.
- Exclusion Blackwood
  A variation of Roman Key Card Blackwood that's used with a void.
- Gerber
  The convention for asking for aces in no-trumps slam auctions.
- Grand Slam Force
  A 5NT bid as a conventional grand slam try.
- Roman Blackwood
  The Italian variation of Blackwood upon which RKCB is based. The responses to 4NT include the rank and colors of the four aces.
- Roman Key Card Blackwood
  A popular variation of Blackwood that asks for aces and the king of trumps.